

The Inimitable Original

Olivia and Dove circled each other, looking for openings. Then, Liv surged forward.

Jab. Jab. Cross. Hook kick.

It was a big move, and, unfortunately, Liv didn't look very natural doing it. Dove was a bit surprised by the double-jab, but she hung with it. Then, the rest was easy. She stepped left and let the cross go by in front of her, then backed out of range when she saw the kick coming. The miss left Liv disoriented and turned slightly to the right. By the time she got herself square again, Dove's right hand was waiting for her. Despite the headgear, the impact was enough to force her to back off and regroup.

"C'mon, Liv!" Ashley shouted from cageside. "Remember what Tiff said. If you're going to go big, you have to be sure you land. And remember... guard, guard guard! You have to recover faster. You can't leave yourself wide-open like that."

Beside her, Tiffany had one eye on the action, and the other on the very animated Tiz.

"How's it going?" I asked as I stepped up beside them.

"It's going," Tiz said without a lot of enthusiasm.

Then she slid down the side of the cage to improve her view.

"Keep moving, Dove! You have to make yourself harder to hit!"

I looked at Tiff.

"You care to add anything to that detailed response?"

"I think it's going pretty well," she said. "Though the most interesting part of it may be watching *Steph, Jr.* here in action."

Yesterday, my guess would have been that Ashley would take that as an insult. Watching her operate now, I wasn't so sure.

"Still having distraction problems?" I asked.

"Not as far as I can tell," Tiff answered. "The wee-uns seem pretty attentive."

A *tsk!* sound emanated from where Zendaya was standing a bit to Tiffany's right.

"Whatchu mean, *wee-uns*?" she asked.

I don't know why, but I love when Daya puts on her street accent. You only need to spend five minutes with the girl to recognize the kind of intelligence she has, and anyone who's ever seen her give an interview can vouch for her speaking ability and composure. But she broke out this simplified level of articulation whenever she wanted to talk tough or lob a few insults. She seems to believe her wisecracks bite a little harder this way, and I have to admit she might be right.

Tiff didn't seem too affected by it, though.

"Hush now, little one," she said. "The adults are talking."

"Man... *little one*?" Zendaya said. "I'm like half a person taller than you are, blondie."

I found it interesting that the rookie was calling the decorated champion names, but Tiff just smiled and let it go.

Believe it or not, this was actually the normal type of banter that goes on between the women here, and I liked to see the rookies getting in on the act. Even if they were biting off more than they could chew.

"Anyway," Tiff continued, "Steph told me a bit about what was going on before, but I didn't see any of that. They've been all business."

"Doesn't really count," Ashley said without turning. "They can't go all fangirl on you because no one knows who the hell you are."

"Kiss my ass, Tiz," Tiff shot back. "I did a guest arc on *Hollyoaks*, and everybody's heard of that. It's been on for over two decades."

Ash responded by turning to Zendaya, who spread her hands as she shrugged.

"Sorry, blondie," she said. "Got no idea what you're talking about."

Her point made, Tiz turned back to the action while Tiff narrowed her eyes at the young rookie beside her. She held the stare for a few seconds, then called out to the pair in the cage.

"Dove, Liv... c'mon out of there," she said. "Z says she wants to give me a try."

"Woah, shit no!" Zendaya said. "I never said nuthin' like that!"

Tiff casually ascended the steps to the cage while strapping on her gloves.

"Make sure you've got your headgear on, rookie," she warned without turning.

Zendaya shook her head and looked to me for relief.

"You ran your mouth," I shrugged. "You get what you get."

"Aw, man... this ain't right!" she complained as she stalked off to face the music. "Y'all need to learn to take a joke!"

"Daya say something stupid?" Danni asked as she came up behind my shoulder.

I turned toward her as I answered.

"Yeah, she... holy crap! What the hell happened to you?"

She was dressed for the cage in a plain black sports bra and shorts, but she was so soaked with sweat that it looked like someone had turned a hose on her. About a third of her hair had pulled loose from her braid, and the strands that weren't matted to her forehead and neck were flying wildly in all directions.

Steph stood beside her, looking equally worn out and dishevelled.

"You told Steph we weren't sparring tonight," Danni said, "so she decided to get in the cage and abuse me herself."

"What makes you think I told her that?" I asked.

"Because she said you did."

I looked at Steph.

"Do you even know what a secret is?"

"Sure," she said, "but your secrets are stupid, so..."

I just grunted in response. Then we all turned our attention forward, watching both the in-cage action and the fervently involved Tiz scooting along the edge of the apron as she barked out commands.

"Ash is pretty intense," Steph said.

"Said the pot to the kettle," Danni commented.

"Tiff actually called her *Steph, Jr.*," I added.

Steph's expression stayed blank.

"Often imitated," she said seriously, "but never duplicated."

Danni and I rolled our eyes in unison.

Steph McMahon. The inimitable original.

After a few more moments of watching, I became acutely aware of Danni standing right next to me, sweating her ass off.

"Could you not stand so close?" I said. "You're gonna drip on me."

"I thought you liked this feeling," she teased.

"Yeah, I like it when I earn it for myself," I said. "I don't need to borrow yours."

"Aww, c'mon..."

She threw her arms out wide and went to hug me.

"Get the fuck away from me!" I yelled as I scampered away. "Are you nuts?"

When I looked back at her, I could see - hidden beneath the sweat and exhaustion - that the smile had reappeared.

Before I knew it, I was smiling too because it was infectious. But it also gave a little shove to the worries I'd managed to hold back for most of the day. I pushed them aside again. No point worrying about it now since I was going to have to face them head on, soon enough.

"Go get yourself cleaned up," I said. "We're getting out of here, soon."

I smiled as I watched her go, then turned serious.

"So, what do you think?" I asked Steph.

She didn't have to ask what I was talking about. Danni's return to the cage was inching closer. She absolutely seemed ready to me, but I wanted to know if Steph was seeing it the same way.

"She's good. As good as I've seen her," she replied.

I smiled again. A different kind of smile, this time.

"I agree," I said. "She's working hard, and it's showing."

"You been doing some kind of strength training with her?" she asked.

"No, but I think knowing she's getting extra time in with me has freed her up to try different things during the day."

"Whatever she's doing is working. She's getting stronger, and she hasn't lost any speed. In fact, she may even be a little faster than she was."

I nodded my agreement. It didn't show up in her striking, so much. Danni had always packed a lot of power into her punches, and that hadn't changed. But she'd become almost impossible to control in the clinch. I'm doing my best to counter by spending some extra time in the weight room myself, but it's becoming obvious that I need to step up that facet of my training.

Meanwhile, the *whatever she's doing* part caught me by surprise.

"You don't know what her routine is?" I asked. "I thought you set everyone's schedule."

"It doesn't really work like that," she said. "There's no one-size-fits-all approach. I give them all the basics, then see how they respond. I don't really know how to explain it."

"You do it by feel, then?"

"Not entirely," she said. "There are metrics I use to spot problems. But, it all comes down to seeing what motivates a fighter."

She didn't say anything more for a good minute, but I've learned to spot the difference between when Steph is done and when she's formulating what she wants to say next.

Having to wait can sometimes be annoying, but it's always worth it.

"Everybody's got their own way," she said. "The rookies here, you have to beat with a stick. It won't be that way forever. They'll either find their motivation, or they'll get sick of losing and quit. Emily and Jules... they like challenges. I set goals, and they go after them. Emma and Tiff drive each other. I mostly try to stay out of their way. Same with Britney and Elisha."

"And Danni?" I asked.

There was another long pause before she answered.

"I've never really understood what drives Danni," she said.

It was a stark admission from a woman who prides herself on always having the answers.

"I think that's part of what went wrong," she continued. "I didn't know what to look for, so I didn't realize it was missing."

"What about your metrics?" I asked.

That drew a rare smile.

"Danni on her worst day is way beyond any metrics I could come up with," she said.

I smiled back. The statement, coupled with her earlier remarks about Danni's speed and power, had me feeling pretty good about the way everything was coming together. But I still had concerns.

"The team event is coming," I said. "Barring an injury substitution, she's going to draw Julie Benz."

Again, I didn't have to explain what I was driving at. Both of us knew this was going to be a serious test for Danni. Benz had held the SCQ welterweight crown for years, and had done it by knocking down some of the biggest names in the league. Though the competition has caught up to her, she is still a perennial title contender and one of the most dangerous women in the weight class. In a fight where anything can happen, Julie's the sort who can take a good break and ride it all the way to victory.

"She's ready," Steph confirmed in her customary, matter-of-fact tone.

I had to fight the urge to do a little victory dance, despite the fact that I'm a terrible dancer.

"I could honestly kiss you right now, Steph."

She gave no reaction, but I bet I'd have gotten one if I actually tried it.

We watched for a few more minutes, but I really wasn't paying any attention because the good news had my spirit soaring. After a while, I decided to make my exit.

"I need to get going," I said. "You good to lock up?"

"No problem."

I turned to go, not realizing she had more to say.

"One good thing came out of this," she said.

I turned to find she had taken her attention away from the cage and was focused completely on me.

"I still don't totally understand her, but I think I know a little more about what motivates her."

Her posture. The set of her jaw. The way she kept her eyes set on mine. All of it came together to make me understand what she meant.

"You're talking about me," I said.

She responded with a single nod that brought me crashing back down to earth.

Now that Danni and I were back to work, I've been reminded of the way she can drag skills out of me that I didn't know I had. It's been happening that way since day one.

I'd been seeing our lost workouts as a missed chance for me to recognize Danni wasn't sharp. Now, Steph was saying there was more to it. That working with me also brought the best out of Danni, and stopping the workouts had taken that tool away.

"Danni has never slacked when it comes to her training," Steph said, "but something about you helps her take it to another level. You challenge her in a way nothing else seems to."

"How do I do that?"

"Well, I've never seen you fight, but my guess? You must be pretty good."

Coming from Steph, that was probably the biggest compliment I'd ever received, but I took no pleasure from it.

"I won't let her down again," I said solemnly.

"Neither will I," she responded.